however, was how ‘the Mirza emulated Babur in his patronage of the Naqshbandi sufi tariqah’.

After his mother was murdered, when Hakim was still a child, the prince had grown increasingly close to Khwaja Hasan Naqshbandi, and through him to his highly orthodox Sufi order, which not only served to give Hakim’s Kabul a clear identity as ‘a bastion of Naqshbandi and orthodox-Sunni Islam’, but also bolstered the prince economically and politically – with its extensive landholdings, for example, or by providing a basis for alliance between Hakim and the increasingly powerful Uzbek ruler to his north, Abdullah Khan of Turan, also a follower of the Naqshbandis.

Given this context, Akbar’s embrace of the Chishtis takes on a whole new dimension. The Chishtis, as Faruqui points out, ‘were a quintessentially Indian Sufi order with few or no ties to either Afghanistan or Central Asia’ – but a definite and popular presence in Punjab ‘where Akbar needed all the support he could get to checkmate Mirza Hakim’s longstanding territorial claims’.[2]

How consciously or not such decisions were made is difficult to say, of course. It is possible that the Naqshbandi order appealed emotionally to Hakim as much as it did strategically – he was an orphaned child, after all, when Khwaja Hasan first came to him. The Chishtis’ ‘eclectic and accommodating religious and spiritual practices’, meanwhile, would certainly have struck a chord with Akbar’s own curious and inventive soul.

The fact of the matter is also, however, that in many public aspects of their lives, the brothers played out a public rivalry. Thus, if Hakim had adopted Babur, then Akbar exerted his claim on their father, Humayun. Humayun’s beautiful tomb, which remains a landmark in Delhi, was built for exactly that purpose: to indicate ‘the new center of an imperial Mughal geography now in Hindustan and under Akbar’s control’. Akbar didn’t just build the tomb. As Faruqui points out, the emperor made several ‘highly publicized visits to [it] . . . between the 1560s and early 1580s’ – between the Uzbek and Bengal revolts that is – and ‘each of these visits . . . occurred against a backdrop of heightened tensions or actual strife with the Mirza [Hakim]’.

Hakim, meanwhile, played his politics in a different coin, quite literally: he banned Akbar’s currency from Kabul in favour of the traditional ‘shahrukhi’ coinage used by Babur and Humayun, as a way of contrasting